

The end of mass immigration

Immigration to the USA had peaked in the years before the First World War. Between 1900 and 1914, more than 10 million immigrants arrived – almost two-thirds of them from eastern, central and southern Europe. The USA had always been a 'nation of immigrants', but there had frequently been a negative reaction against newcomers from those who had established themselves earlier. For example, in 1882 the Chinese Exclusion Act restricted immigrants from China; in 1907 immigration from Japan was reduced by a diplomatic agreement between the USA and Japan.

In 1907, the Dillingham Commission, set up by Congress, investigated immigration and reported that many immigrants from newer parts of Europe were not finding it easy to assimilate and that this was causing economic and social problems. By this time, there was also pressure from trades unions, especially the American Federation of Labor (AFL), to restrict the inflow of cheap immigrant labour. There were increasing calls to stop or reduce immigration by establishing a literacy test for immigrants, but this had little effect on government policy at first because all the main political parties were opposed to it.

Attitudes changed during the First World War. The flow of immigration was halted during the conflict. The war intensified fear and hostility towards 'aliens', whose loyalty was seen as unreliable. Support for the **restrictionists** increased and in 1917 Congress finally adopted the Literacy Test, which required immigrants to be able to speak English to qualify for entry into the USA. This law also contained clauses deliberately designed to reduce immigration from Asia. Anti-foreigner feeling was also reflected in the Espionage Act 1917 and the Sedition Act 1918, legislation that was strongly influenced by the idea that recently arrived immigrants were a danger to national security. The 'Red Scare' made such views even more popular in 1919–20.

Restrictionists were unhappy when immigration, mostly from western Europe, picked up again after the war, with new arrivals totalling more than 400,000 each year. Strong pressure was placed on Congress. In 1921, the Emergency Quota Act was passed, the first time there had ever been numerical limits on inward migration. Quotas were set at 3 per cent of the numbers of people from any country in the 1910 census. The act aimed at restricting immigration to below 350,000 people per year – half from northern Europe, half from southern and eastern Europe. This kept the numbers arriving from northern Europe unchanged but cut other immigration by 70 per cent.

However, the Emergency Quota Act was not enough to satisfy the restrictionists. In 1924, another act, sometimes known as the National Origins (Quota) Act, changed the rules so that numbers would be calculated at 2 per cent of the 1890 census. This deliberately discriminated against ethnic groups who had had high levels of immigration since 1890, and favoured people from northern and western Europe. The hope was that annual immigration would settle at about 165,000. Despite the legal restrictions, however, immigration continued at fairly high levels. The overall total for the 1920s was more than 4 million. It was not the Emergency Quota Act that finally slowed immigration from Europe to a trickle after 1930 but the impact of the Great Depression.



Fig. 3 An anti-immigration poster

Key term

Restrictionists: those who wanted to cut down or stop altogether the flow of immigration.

Cross-reference

The 'Red Scare' is covered in more detail on pages 60–64.

Exploring the detail

The Sedition Act

This act extended the Espionage Act 1917 so that it covered 'scurrilous or abusive language against the United States form of government'. More than 900 people were imprisoned. In the 'Red Scare' of 1919–20, the powers given to the authorities by these acts were used extensively by Attorney General A. Mitchell Palmer (see pages 62–4).

Table 2 Immigration statistics, 1920–9

Country or area of origin	Percentage of annual total
Britain and Ireland	8
Germany and northern Europe	9
Central and eastern Europe	14
Southern Europe	16
Canada and Latin America	27

Total during the period: 4.2 million
Annual average: 412,000

Although the total of new immigrants was below 5 million, birth rates in the 1920s meant that the total population increase between 1920 and 1929 was more than 16 million.

The introduction of Prohibition

The changed social and political situation after the First World War enabled supporters of Prohibition to achieve their goal. The temperance movement had been a prominent feature of local and national politics for more than a generation before the war. In 1919, there was at last a Congressional majority in favour of Prohibition. Between the passing of the Volstead Act in 1919 and the repeal of Prohibition in 1933, a great social experiment began, with profound and sometimes unexpected consequences for the USA.

Prohibition had deep roots. Numerous organisations, especially at local level, had campaigned against the evils of alcohol during the 19th century. The pressure for reform increased in reaction to urbanisation and mass immigration after 1890. The Prohibition movement received strong support from Protestant religious groups and women activists. One of the most vocal organisations was the Woman's Christian Temperance Union (WCTU), but the most effective in terms of political action was the Anti-Saloon League. The Anti-Saloon League was founded in Ohio in 1893, although its origins went back to 1869. It became a national organisation in 1895. The league's most influential leader, Wayne Wheeler, led an aggressive campaign of grass-roots pressure politics, often known as 'Wheelerism', directed at gaining support from Progressives in the two main political parties rather than working through the Prohibition Party.



Fig. 4 The evils of drink and Prohibition

Activity

Revision exercise

Using the information in this chapter, outline the main reasons why many Americans were in favour of restrictions on immigration after 1918.

Activity

Statistical analysis

Study Table 2.

- 1 What are the most notable patterns of immigration?
- 2 How do these patterns differ from the years before the First World War?
- 3 What do these statistics tell us about the effectiveness of efforts to restrict immigration?

Cross-reference

See pages 25–6 for further material on the WCTU and the early campaign for Prohibition.